

**CONSUMER PREFERENCES FOR SMALL-UNIT PURCHASING: AN ANALYSIS
OF THE INFLUENCE OF SOCIO-ECONOMIC FACTORS ON SARI-SARI STORE
CUSTOMERS IN SAKLANGAN, VERDANT HOMES SABANG NAIC, CAVITE**

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Chapter 1: The Problem and Its Background

A. Introduction

The practice of purchasing goods in small quantities has its roots in the economic conditions faced by low-income consumers in developing economies (Deaton, 2015). When income is limited or irregular, households adapt their purchasing behavior to match short-term cash availability rather than long-term consumption planning (Deaton, 2015). Households with constrained income often prioritize immediate needs and liquidity, purchasing goods in quantities that align with daily or weekly budgets instead of bulk volumes (Deaton, 2015). This adaptive behavior reflects not a lack of preference for larger quantities, but a structural response to income volatility and budget limitations (Prahalad, 2016). Consumers at the lower end of the income distribution frequently rely on small, incremental purchases as a means of managing financial risk and maintaining consumption stability (Prahalad, 2016). Poverty shapes decision-making by limiting the capacity to plan for future consumption, thereby encouraging purchasing behaviors that favor immediacy and affordability (Banerjee & Duflo, 2019).

Consumer purchasing behavior, in general, is influenced by income, price sensitivity, and access to retail outlets, all of which determine how individuals allocate limited financial resources (Manalo, 2025). In the Philippines, small-unit purchasing locally known as *tingi* buying has emerged as a common strategy among low- and middle-income households (Reyes, 2025). *Tingi* purchasing allows consumers to manage limited disposable income by buying only what they can afford at a given time, effectively stretching their household budget to meet immediate needs (Reyes, 2025). Recent studies indicate that monthly spending per consumer in

neighborhood retail outlets has declined over the past two years (Santos, 2025), while the frequency of smaller purchases has increased (Cruz, 2025). This pattern reflects adaptation to ongoing budget constraints and financial limitations in low-income households (Santos, 2025; Cruz, 2025).

Sari-sari stores, small community-based retail outlets, play a central role in facilitating tingi purchases (Villanueva, 2025). These stores provide accessible retail options for households with limited income, offering basic goods in flexible quantities that align with consumers' budgets and socio-economic realities (Villanueva, 2025). Studies show a decline in average spending per visit (Cruz, 2025) alongside an increase in the number of monthly transactions (Santos, 2025), indicating that consumers are spreading their purchases across multiple, smaller transactions to manage limited household budgets effectively (Cruz, 2025; Santos, 2025).

Despite the prevalence of small-unit purchasing, localized studies examining the socio-economic drivers behind this behavior remain limited (Manalo, 2025). Most existing research addresses national or regional spending trends without fully capturing how income levels, household budget constraints, and expenditure priorities influence consumer choices in specific communities (Reyes, 2025). This gap highlights the need for focused studies that assess these dynamics at the community level (Villanueva, 2025).

This study was conducted to examine consumer preferences for small-unit purchasing among sari-sari store customers, focusing specifically on the influence of socio-economic factors such as budget and income (Manalo, 2025; Reyes, 2025).

The reason for conducting this study is to understand how financial constraints shape daily purchasing decisions in households with limited income (Manalo, 2025). Its relevance lies in providing practical insights for store owners to improve inventory management and pricing strategies (Reyes, 2025), and for suppliers to design products that meet local demand for small-unit goods (Villanueva, 2025). The importance of the study extends to policymakers and researchers, as it contributes to a deeper understanding of consumer welfare (Banerjee & Duflo, 2019), economic resilience (Santos, 2025), and informal retail dynamics in low-income communities where small-unit purchasing is central to daily consumption (Villanueva, 2025).

In summary, understanding consumer preferences for small-unit purchasing provides valuable insights into how households manage their limited resources. By examining the buying behavior of sari-sari store customers in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite this study aims to highlight the practical and socio-economic factors that shape daily consumption patterns. The findings are expected to inform strategies for store management, product distribution, and community economic development, while contributing to a deeper appreciation of how local consumers navigate financial constraints in their everyday lives.

B. Statement of the Problem

This study aims to determine consumer preferences for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in Saklangan, Verdant Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite. Specifically, it seeks to examine how demographic characteristics, income level, budget limitations, and selected socio-economic factors influence consumers' purchasing decisions. More importantly, the study aims to explain small-unit

purchasing as an adaptive strategy employed by households to manage limited and unstable financial resources. In line with these objectives, this study seeks to answer the following questions:

1. Who are more likely to engage in small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in terms of demographic characteristics such as:
 - a. age
 - b. sex
 - c. civil status
2. What is the income level of consumers who engage in small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in Saklangan, Verdant Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite?
3. How do consumers' budget limitations influence their small-unit purchasing behavior?
4. What selected socio-economic factors are associated with consumers' preference for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in terms of:
 - a. household size
 - b. employment type
 - c. educational attainment
 - d. household responsibilities
5. How does small-unit purchasing function as an adaptive strategy for consumers in managing limited and unstable income when meeting daily household consumption needs?

C. Theoretical Framework

This study examines how income level, budget limitations, and socio-economic factors influence consumers' preference for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite. It is anchored on three relevant theories that explain consumer behavior in low-income communities.

Theory 1: Theory of Budget Constraint

According to Varian (2019), the Theory of Budget Constraint explains that consumers make decisions based on the limits of their available income and the prices of goods. In households with limited financial resources, these constraints strongly determine purchasing patterns, as families must prioritize spending to remain within their budgets. Varian (2019) emphasizes that consumers attempt to maximize utility while adhering to financial limits. When income is restricted, households adjust the quantity and frequency of purchases. In the context of sari-sari stores, this manifests as buying goods in small units, allowing consumers to manage daily expenditures without exceeding budget limitations. Varian's (2019) theory is relevant to this study because it directly supports the inclusion of budget limitations as an independent variable. It explains why consumers with constrained budgets prefer small-unit purchasing as a rational strategy to maintain financial stability.

Theory 2: Life-Cycle Theory of Consumption

Deaton (2015) explains that the Life-Cycle Theory of Consumption posits that consumers plan spending based on expected lifetime income. However, households with low or irregular-income face difficulty smoothing consumption, which affects their short-term purchasing behavior. Deaton (2015) highlights that when

income is unpredictable, households prioritize immediate needs and adopt strategies that match available cash flow. Small-unit purchasing becomes a practical approach to ensure daily necessities are met without overspending. In sari-sari stores, this allows consumers to adjust their purchases according to fluctuating income. This theory justifies the inclusion of income level as a variable in this study. According to Deaton (2015), income constraints directly influence small-unit purchasing, demonstrating the connection between irregular or low income and adaptive consumption behavior.

Theory 3: Consumer Choice Theory

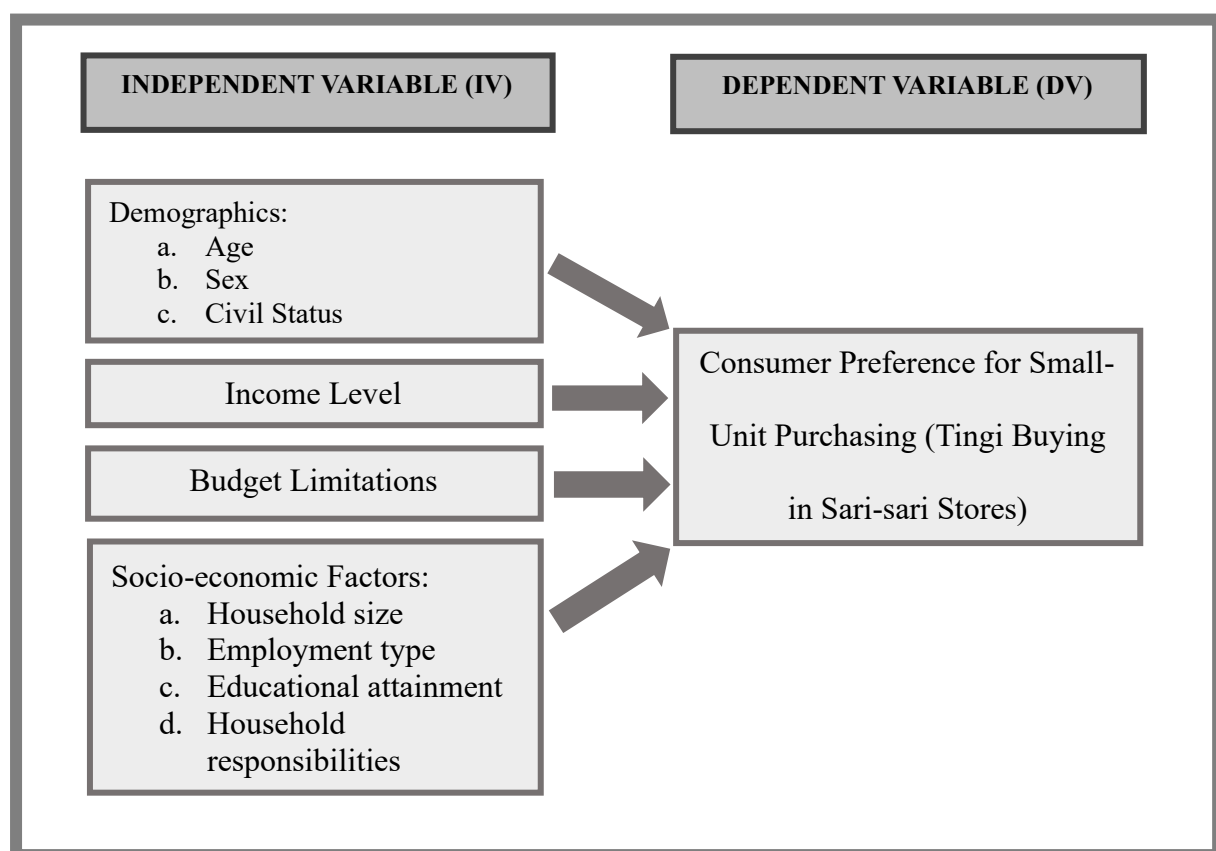
Samuelson and Nordhaus (2018) state that Consumer Choice Theory explains how individuals allocate limited resources to satisfy competing needs and maximize satisfaction. Consumers' choices are influenced by income, prices, and personal circumstances, including socio-economic factors. According to Samuelson and Nordhaus (2018), socio-economic conditions such as employment status, household responsibilities, and family size influence purchasing decisions. In low-income communities, these factors affect whether households buy goods in bulk or in small units. Small-unit purchasing allows consumers to meet essential needs while managing limited financial resources. This theory supports the inclusion of selected socio-economic factors as independent variables. Samuelson and Nordhaus (2018) provide a rationale for examining how these factors shape consumers' preference for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores.

Together, the theories of Varian (2019), Deaton (2015), and Samuelson & Nordhaus (2018) provide a comprehensive explanation for why consumers prefer

small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores. Budget limitations, income level, and socio-economic factors jointly determine consumer behavior in low-income communities.

D. Conceptual Framework

Figure 1: Independent Variable (IV) Dependent Variable (DV) Model of Factors Influencing Small-Unit Purchasing in Sari-sari Stores



Consumer purchasing behavior is shaped by a combination of demographic, economic, and socio-economic factors, which influence how individuals manage limited financial resources. Research indicates that income level and budget constraints play a significant role in purchasing decisions, particularly among low-income consumers who prioritize affordability and immediate needs (Banerjee & Duflo,

2019). Demographic characteristics, such as age, sex, and household composition, further affect consumption patterns and buying preferences (Schiffman & Wisenblit, 2019). Likewise, socio-economic conditions, including employment status and educational attainment, are important determinants of product choice and purchasing behavior (OECD, 2020). In response to income instability and daily budget limitations, small-unit purchasing, or tingi buying, has emerged as a common coping strategy in developing economies (Mazzucato, 2021).

Guided by these insights, the present study adopts a conceptual framework that examines how demographic profile, income level, budget limitations, and socio-economic factors influence consumers' preference for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores. The independent variables demographic profile, income level, budget limitations, and socio-economic factors are posited to directly affect consumers' purchasing behavior. This framework offers a structured approach for analyzing relationships among these variables and provides a foundation for interpreting the study's findings, particularly among consumers in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang, Naic, Cavite.

E. Scope and Delimitation

This study focuses on consumer preferences for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores located in Saklangan and Verdant Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite, aiming to examine how income level, budget limitations, and selected socio-economic factors influence the decision to buy goods in small quantities to know how does small-unit purchasing function as an adaptive strategy for consumers in managing limited and unstable income when meeting daily household consumption needs. Using a

quantitative research design, data are collected through structured questionnaires from consumers, and both descriptive and inferential statistical methods are applied to analyze the relationships between these factors and small-unit purchasing behavior.

The study includes a total of 150 respondents who regularly purchase small-unit goods from sari-sari stores within the study area. Of these, 75 respondents are drawn from Saklangan and 75 respondents from Verdant Homes, ensuring equal representation of consumer purchasing behavior in both communities. This distribution allows for a balanced analysis of small-unit purchasing preferences between the two locations while remaining within the defined scope of the research.

The study is limited to consumers who regularly purchase small-unit goods from sari-sari stores, which vary in their offerings, including general merchandise, pharmaceuticals, meat and frozen goods, school supplies, rice, and other basic necessities. The socio-economic factors considered include household size, employment type, education level, and household responsibilities, reflecting the realities of a community where most residents have unstable and low-income jobs in informal sectors such as construction, factory work, market selling, or personal services, often without permanent employment.

The findings are specific to Saklangan and Verdant Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite, and cannot be generalized to other areas. Only small-unit purchases of basic necessities are examined, excluding bulk or specialty items, and the study relies solely on quantitative methods without qualitative approaches such as interviews or observations. Data collection reflects consumer behavior only during the period of the

study, providing a focused understanding of how households manage limited income and budgets. The results are intended to offer practical insights for store owners, suppliers, and local policymakers in supporting community consumption needs.

F. Significance of the Study

Small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores reflects how households manage limited income and budget constraints in meeting daily consumption needs. Understanding this behavior provides insights into consumer decision-making and informal retail dynamics in low-income communities. This study is significant to various stakeholders who are directly and indirectly affected by consumer preferences for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite. By examining the influence of income level, budget limitations, and selected socio-economic factors. Thus, the findings would benefit different entities, to with:

Consumers. From low- and middle-income households may benefit from the study by gaining a clearer understanding of how budget constraints and income conditions influence their purchasing behavior. The findings may promote greater awareness of spending patterns and support more informed decision-making in managing daily consumption needs.

Local Policymakers. Local government units and policymakers may use the results of this study as empirical support in developing programs and policies related to consumer welfare, livelihood assistance, and community-based economic planning. The findings offer insights into how informal retail systems support household consumption in low-income communities.

Researchers and Future Scholars. This study contributes to the existing literature on consumer behavior and small-unit purchasing at the community level. Researchers and future scholars may use the findings as a reference for related studies, particularly those focusing on informal retail, socio-economic factors, and consumption behavior in low-income settings.

Sari-sari Store Owners. They may benefit from the study by understanding consumers' preferences, purchasing frequency, and budget-driven buying behavior. The findings can assist store owners in improving inventory selection, pricing decisions, and product availability that align with customers' financial capacity.

Suppliers and Distributors. They may use the study's findings to better understand the demand for small-unit goods in sari-sari stores. This may guide decisions on product packaging, pricing strategies, and distribution approaches suited to low-income communities.

This study enhances understanding of small-unit purchasing as an adaptive response to financial and socio-economic constraints. The findings are expected to support informed decision-making among stakeholders involved in community retail, economic development, and consumer welfare in low-income communities.

G. Definition of Terms

To ensure better understanding, the following terms used in the research study are defined conceptually and operationally. To clarify how it is applied or measured in the context of consumer preferences for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite.

Budget Limitations. Refer to financial constraints that restrict the ability of individuals or households to allocate sufficient resources for consumption. These limitations arise when income is limited or irregular, requiring households to prioritize essential needs and carefully manage spending decisions (Varian, 2019; Banerjee & Duflo, 2019).

In this study, budget limitations refer to the degree to which consumers' available daily or weekly funds restrict their ability to purchase goods in larger quantities. This variable is measured through survey items related to cash availability, difficulty in budgeting, and reliance on small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite.

Consumer Preference. Refers to an individual's tendency to choose certain goods or purchasing options over others based on perceived utility, affordability, and personal needs. Such preferences are influenced by income, prices, experience, and socio-economic conditions (Samuelson & Nordhaus, 2018; Kotler & Keller, 2022).

In this study, consumer preference refers to consumers' inclination to purchase goods in small quantities rather than in bulk from sari-sari stores. It is

measured through the reported frequency of small-unit purchases and responses to survey statements related to affordability and purchasing choices.

Income Level. Refers to the amount of monetary earnings received by an individual or household within a specific period, which determines purchasing power and the capacity to consume goods and services (Deaton, 2015; World Bank, 2021).

In this study, income level refers to respondents' reported monthly household income. It is categorized into income brackets and analyzed in relation to budget limitations and consumers' preference for small-unit purchasing.

Sari-sari Store. A sari-sari store is a small, community-based retail outlet in the Philippines that sells basic household goods and daily necessities, often in flexible or small quantities, and forms part of the informal retail system (Villanueva, 2025; Reyes, 2025)

In this study, sari-sari stores refer to neighborhood retail shops located in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite, where consumers regularly purchase basic necessities and engage in small-unit purchasing practices.

Small-Unit Purchasing. Refers to the practice of buying goods in minimal quantities instead of bulk amounts. This behavior is commonly adopted by consumers managing limited income and prioritizing immediate consumption needs (Prahalad, 2016; Santos, 2025).

In this study, small-unit purchasing refers to the purchase of goods in sachets, single pieces, or small portions from sari-sari stores. It is measured through the frequency of such purchases and the types of products bought by consumers.

Socio-economic Factors. Refer to the social and economic characteristics of individuals or households that influence behavior and decision-making, including employment status, education level, and household composition (Samuelson & Nordhaus, 2018; Manalo, 2025).

In this study, socio-economic factors include household size, type of employment, educational attainment, and household responsibilities. These factors are measured using structured survey questions and analyzed in relation to consumer preference for small-unit purchasing.

Tingi Buying. Is a locally used Philippine term that describes the purchase of goods in very small quantities and reflects adaptive consumption behavior among households with limited financial resources (Reyes, 2025; Cruz, 2025).

In this study, tingi buying is used interchangeably with small-unit purchasing and refers to buying basic necessities in small quantities from sari-sari stores in Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite, as measured through consumer purchase frequency and product size.

These definitions establish clarity and consistency in the use of terminology throughout the study. By providing both conceptual and operational

meanings, the section ensures that the variables, constructs, and local practices relevant to small-unit purchasing are well-understood and accurately applied in data collection, analysis, and interpretation.

Chapter 2: Review of Related Literatures

This presents the Review of Related Literature, which serves as the foundation for understanding consumer preferences for small-unit purchasing in sari-sari stores. This chapter synthesizes local and international studies from 2015–2025, highlighting the influence of income level, budget limitations, and socio-economic factors on consumption behavior. The literature also provides context on the role of sari-sari stores in low-income communities, establishing the relevance of this study.

Consumer Preferences for Small-Unit Purchasing

According to Deaton (2015), consumer preference for small-unit purchasing emerges when households face limited or irregular income, pushing them to adjust consumption patterns to match daily or weekly cash availability instead of planning for bulk purchases. Deaton's work emphasizes that this preference is a rational adaptation to budget uncertainty rather than a mere habit or preference for convenience.

According to Prahalad (2016), consumers at the base of the economic pyramid often prefer smaller quantities because they reduce immediate financial risk and enable continuity of consumption under tight budget constraints. Similarly, Banerjee and Duflo (2019) argue that poverty limits choice sets and forces households

to make consumption decisions that prioritize immediacy and affordability over volume discounts. According to Nielsen (2020), markets serving low-income segments are dominated by smaller, single-use products — not because of higher utility, but because they align with constrained cash flows.

According to Narayan and Pritchett (2019), studies across Africa, Asia, and Latin America show that incremental purchasing is a widespread strategy among low-income households coping with income volatility. According to Reyes (2025), Filipino consumers in both urban and peri-urban communities demonstrate a consistent preference for small-unit purchases, particularly for food and household essentials, reinforcing that tingi buying is not an isolated phenomenon but part of established consumption behavior.

Factors Influencing Small-Unit Purchasing

According to Samuelson and Nordhaus (2018), consumer choice involves complex interactions between income, prices, and available resources; when these factors operate under constraint, households adjust purchasing behavior to maintain consumption without exceeding limited budgets. This framework underlies much of the literature on small-unit purchasing.

According to Santos (2025), financial instability and rising cost of living increase the frequency of small purchases while decreasing the quantity per transaction. In these contexts, households fragment purchases to preserve liquidity and reduce exposure to budget shocks. According to the OECD (2019), in regions with limited formal retail infrastructure and high levels of informal employment, households

rely on multiple small, frequent purchases through informal retail networks, reinforcing the link between market structure and consumption strategies.

According to Manalo (2025), households with limited access to credit and formal banking services use small-unit purchases as a form of self-insurance against financial uncertainty. Similarly, according to D'Souza and Sharma (2017), cultural norms, social practices, and community expectations further shape consumption decisions, as incremental purchasing becomes both an economic necessity and a socially reinforced behavior. According to Leung et al. (2021), consumer behavior under constraint also reflects psychological coping strategies, where smaller purchases deliver perceived control and predictability in uncertain financial environments.

Income Level

According to Deaton (2015), income level remains one of the most significant determinants of consumption behavior; households with low or unpredictable income experience difficulty planning future consumption, resulting in short-term, cash-based purchasing decisions. Deaton's foundational work emphasizes the link between income volatility and fragmented purchasing.

According to the World Bank (2021), data from developing countries show that lower-income households allocate a larger portion of their budgets to essential goods, often in smaller, frequent purchases to avoid large cash outlays. According to the Asian Development Bank (2020), income inequality and labor

informality in emerging economies contribute to narrow consumption bands and frequent small-unit buying due to limited savings.

According to Reyes (2025) and Villanueva (2025), in the Philippine context, income level significantly predicts the likelihood of engaging in tingi buying, as consumers with lower monthly earnings purchase smaller quantities to manage daily budget constraints. According to Wang and Huang (2018), even slight variations in household income correlate with significant changes in consumption patterns, with wealthier households showing greater propensity for bulk purchases and formal retail usage.

According to Cruz and Fernandez (2023), longitudinal studies in Southeast Asia confirm that income shocks such as job loss or medical expenses directly influence purchasing frequency and unit size, reinforcing that income dynamics are central to understanding consumption choices in low-income settings.

Budget Limitations

According to Varian (2019), budget limitations frame consumer choice by defining the maximum set of goods and quantities households can afford given their income and prevailing prices. This conceptualization places budget constraints at the core of consumption theories for low-income populations.

According to Banerjee and Duflo (2019), budgetary pressure narrows the planning horizon of households, compelling them to prioritize immediate consumption needs over long-term cost minimization strategies such as bulk

purchases. According to Chetty et al. (2018), households under tighter budget constraints exhibit heightened sensitivity to price changes and are more likely to choose incremental consumption to avoid large upfront costs.

According to Santos (2025), Filipino households with constrained daily or weekly budgets use small-unit purchases as a mechanism to manage expenditure without exceeding financial limits, allowing households to adjust consumption dynamically based on real-time cash availability. According to Cruz (2025), budget limitations are observed not only in food purchases but also in hygiene and personal care products, suggesting that budget constraint effects are pervasive across different categories of household goods.

According to Adeyemi and Ogunniyi (2019), in West African contexts, budget limitations interact with market unpredictability to reinforce small-unit purchasing as a survival mechanism. According to Gupta (2020), research in South Asia similarly shows that budget constraints reduce consumers' willingness to hold inventory, further driving preference for frequent, smaller purchases.

Socio-Economic Factors

According to Samuelson and Nordhaus (2018), socio-economic factors such as employment, education, household structure, and social supports influence household consumption strategies by shaping both capacity and priorities. These factors are interdependent and interact with income and budget limitations when determining consumer behavior.

According to Manalo (2025), socio-economically vulnerable households are more reliant on informal retail outlets and small-unit purchasing due to limited access to formal financial services, credit, and savings mechanisms. According to the United Nations Development Programme (2020), socio-economic disadvantage consistently correlates with constrained consumption behavior in developing contexts, influencing how households plan and execute purchases.

According to Nguyen and Tran (2018), socio-economic status also affects perception of financial risk and future uncertainty, shaping behaviors such as delayed bulk purchases and reliance on frequent, smaller transactions. According to Sarpong and Awunyo-Vitor (2017), in African markets, socio-economic pressures such as fluctuating income and job instability lead to highly elastic consumption patterns, with small-unit purchasing serving as a buffer to financial stress.

According to Dela Cruz and Mendoza (2022), localized research in the Philippines confirms that factors like informal employment, household debt, and lack of social safety nets reinforce small-unit purchasing behaviors, especially among households with limited financial resilience.

Price Sensitivity and Perceived Affordability

According to Kotler and Keller (2022), price sensitivity is a key determinant of purchasing behavior, particularly for households with limited disposable income. Price sensitivity influences how consumers evaluate cost in relation to quantity, often prompting incremental purchases when the immediate cost of larger quantities appears prohibitive.

According to Chetty et al. (2018), households under financial stress may accept a higher price per unit for smaller quantities because such purchases require lower immediate cash outlay, even if they are economically less efficient over time. According to Kadiyala and Doss (2015), price perception drives low-income consumers toward small-unit purchases, especially for daily necessities.

According to Sheth (2020), consumer price sensitivity varies across socio-economic segments but is particularly pronounced when households experience budget volatility. According to Trinidad (2023), Filipino consumers often view small-unit purchases as more affordable because they fit within daily income availability, despite the higher per-unit cost relative to bulk items.

According to Alhassan et al. (2021), research in West Africa indicates that households rationalize higher unit prices when immediate cash constraints preclude bulk purchases, demonstrating that perceived affordability is as influential as actual price.

Cultural and Social Influences

According to Banerjee and Duflo (2019), cultural and social norms significantly shape consumption behaviors, particularly in low-income contexts where community practices influence purchasing patterns. Incremental purchasing is often embedded in cultural consumption routines rather than merely an economic response.

According to D'Souza and Sharma (2017), social networks and shared community expectations shape individual consumption decisions, reinforcing

normative behaviors such as frequent small-unit purchases. According to Garcia and Pascual (2021), Filipino social norms around community reciprocity, shared consumption experiences, and informal credit systems further entrench *tingi* buying as a collective behavior rather than a purely financial strategy.

According to Singh and Sinha (2018), in South Asian communities, social rituals around food, celebrations, and household management reinforce incremental purchasing patterns, as households frequently purchase small quantities to match communal practices. According to Christian et al. (2020), social identity and group norms influence consumer perceptions of value and affordability, often reinforcing behaviors that reflect collective economic realities rather than individual rational choice.

Household Size

According to Deaton (2015), household size significantly affects consumption patterns, as larger households face greater total expenditure requirements and stretched financial resources. Larger families often adopt incremental purchasing strategies to balance aggregate needs with limited income.

According to Becker (2016), consumption decisions in larger households tend to prioritize quantity flexibility and incremental access to essentials, particularly when budgeting constraints are strict. According to Hong and Kristensen (2018), households with more dependents are more likely to fragment purchases to maintain financial stability across broader consumption needs.

According to Cruz (2025) and Lopez and Santos (2021), Philippine households with larger family sizes correlate with higher frequency of tingi buying, particularly for food staples and household goods. According to Silva and Ratnayake (2017), research in South Asian contexts shows that larger household size moderates the relationship between income and consumption, reinforcing incremental purchasing as a cost-management strategy.

According to Mabeya et al. (2019), studies in East Africa highlight that larger households often demonstrate more complex consumption cycles, using small-unit purchases to smooth variability in expenditure.

Employment Type

According to Banerjee and Duflo (2019), employment status is directly linked to income stability, with informal or irregular employment characteristic of the informal sector creating volatile income flows that discourage bulk purchasing.

According to Manalo (2025), consumers engaged in informal, casual, or temporary labor are more likely to buy goods in small quantities to match unpredictable earnings. According to the International Labour Organization (2021), informal workers commonly lack income security and social protections, reinforcing adaptive strategies such as small-unit purchases to avoid cash shortages.

According to Nguyen, Tran, and Sun (2019), employment instability increases dependency on incremental consumption to maintain household liquidity. According to Al-Mamun and Hasan (2020), households with fluctuating employment

contracts maintain higher liquidity by spreading purchases over smaller transactions. According to Okoye and Eze (2017), research in West Africa indicates that informal employment correlates positively with frequency of small purchases due to fluctuating income patterns and limited savings.

Education Attainment

According to Kotler and Keller (2022), education level influences financial decision-making, price comparison skills, and consumption planning. Educated consumers may better understand long-term savings and budgeting, but structural constraints such as limited income still influence actual purchase execution.

According to Reyes (2025), even well-educated individuals engage in tindi buying when they face constrained financial conditions, suggesting that education affects knowledge but may not always translate into bulk purchasing strategies when budget and income are limited. According to Lusardi and Mitchell (2017), financial literacy enhances financial planning, but may not fully mitigate the impact of economic constraints on consumption behavior.

According to Jackson, Graciela, and Lee (2018), education shapes attitudes toward saving and financial planning, but the constraints of income volatility may override these attitudes in day-to-day purchasing decisions. According to Chinen and Malgwi (2019), research in Latin America notes that higher educational attainment does not necessarily reduce frequency of small purchases when households face economic insecurity.

Household Responsibilities

According to Deaton (2015), household responsibilities such as caregiving for children or elderly members shape resource allocation and purchasing patterns, often amplifying financial pressures that lead to frequent small purchases.

According to UNICEF (2019), families with dependents bear greater financial burdens due to caregiving demands, reinforcing conservative consumption strategies such as incremental purchases. According to Chen and Wilson (2017), caregiving obligations increase expenditure volatility, prompting families to choose purchase cycles that align with daily cash flows rather than bulk needs.

According to Cruz (2025), Philippine households with significant caregiving roles favor small-unit purchasing to balance daily consumption needs with limited financial resources. According to Asante and Osei (2018), research in Ghana indicates that household responsibilities significantly influence consumption pacing and budgeting strategies in ways that favor frequent small purchases over larger bulk expenditures.

Small-Unit Purchasing as an Adaptive Household Strategy

Recent studies on consumer purchasing behavior in the Philippine micro-retail environment highlight how small-unit purchasing has become a practical coping strategy for households facing limited and unstable income. According to Asianews (2024), transactional data from over one million monthly purchases at sari-sari stores nationwide show that average monthly spending per consumer declined to PHP 689 in 2024, down from PHP 800 in 2022, while the frequency of store visits

increased. This indicates a shift toward smaller, more frequent purchases characteristic of “tingi” buying. According to Asianews (2024), this pattern reflects consumers’ need to stretch constrained budgets by acquiring only essential items they can afford at a given time, rather than making larger purchases requiring higher upfront costs. Analysts interpret this behavior as an adaptive response to financial limitations, where buying minimal quantities allows households to manage daily consumption needs despite income instability and budget pressures. Such purchasing patterns are consistent with broader observations on how low-income consumers adjust consumption strategies under economic constraints, making the tingi economy a salient example of adaptive consumer behavior in developing contexts.

According to Asianews (2025), empirical evidence underscores how financial limitations drive consumer behavior toward small-unit purchases in the Philippines. A 2025 micro-retail analytics study reported that average monthly spending at sari-sari stores dropped from PHP 800 in 2022 to PHP 689 in 2024, even as consumers visited stores more frequently. According to Asianews (2025), this “tingi” buying pattern reflects a strategic adaptation to tight household budgets: by limiting purchases to immediate needs, consumers maintain consumption without overextending limited financial resources. Such behavior illustrates how small-unit purchasing functions as a household coping mechanism in the face of persistent economic constraints.

According to Bworld (2025), the rise of small-unit purchasing represents a broader economic adjustment among low-income households under budget pressure. Data from Packworks’ sari-sari store network show not only a shrinking

basket size but also increased transaction frequency, suggesting that consumers restructure consumption patterns to manage constrained purchasing power. According to Bworld (2025), consumers stretch limited disposable income by buying only essential items in minimal quantities, highlighting the functional role of the “tingi” economy in everyday survival strategies. Increased reliance on sari-sari stores for small-unit goods demonstrates how consumers modulate buying behavior in response to macroeconomic pressures, reinforcing the interpretation of small-unit purchasing as an adaptive response rather than a temporary trend.

According to E-Palli (2023), qualitative research on sari-sari store operations supports the understanding of micro-purchasing as an adaptive strategy rooted in economic necessity. Although primarily focused on store challenges, multiple case studies reveal that customer behavior driven by tight household budgets and irregular income flows compels store owners to maintain stock of low-cost, small-quantity items appealing to budget-constrained buyers. According to E-Palli (2023), pricing pressures and limited capital compel store owners to offer smaller units to attract regular patronage, illustrating the reciprocal adaptation between consumers and micro-retailers in managing financial vulnerability. This symbiotic relationship highlights how small-unit purchasing functions not only as a consumer coping strategy but also as a stabilizing mechanism within local economies where formal retail alternatives may be less accessible.

According to Divina, Guerra, and San Juan (2019), local research on consumer behavior in Philippine sari-sari stores highlights how purchasing decisions in micro-retail environments are shaped by financial constraints and household needs.

Their study found that consumers in low-income communities often prioritize the purchase of small, affordable quantities of goods to manage limited budgets and meet daily consumption requirements, a behavior consistent with the “tingi” purchasing culture prevalent in the Philippines. According to Divina (2019), this adaptive strategy enables households to balance immediate needs against irregular income flows by spreading limited financial resources over time rather than committing to larger, bulk purchases that require more substantial upfront expenditures. Such findings reinforce the understanding of small-unit purchasing not merely as a cultural practice but as an economically driven coping mechanism among budget-constrained Filipino consumers.

According to Alladin, Limon, Oblea, and Cabauatan (2022), studies on sachet consumption and consumer preferences in Quezon City demonstrate how “tingi” culture has become deeply embedded in Filipino purchasing practices, particularly among households managing limited budgets. Their research found that affordability, convenience, and household income significantly influence consumers’ preference for sachet products, which are typically sold in small units that align with daily expenditure capacities. According to Alladin (2022), economic constraints and budget sensitivity drive Filipino consumers to prefer small-pack purchases as a rational strategy for managing scarce financial resources, even among middle-income households. Purchasing these micro-pack products allows consumers to exercise greater control over their budgets by limiting expenditures to immediate needs, reinforcing the role of small-unit buying as an adaptive consumption behavior in local retail settings.

Sari-sari Stores

According to Minten, Reardon, and Sur (2020), sari-sari stores represent a form of micro-retail that provides essential goods in flexible quantities and facilitates access for consumers with limited income. These stores adapt to financial constraints by offering repackaged goods and small quantities that match consumer cash flow.

According to Reardon and Timmer (2019), proximity and low transaction costs make small retailers vital in low-income areas where formal retail outlets may be distant, expensive, or inaccessible. According to Mendez and Castañeda (2018), informal retail environments provide solutions that formal systems cannot, offering flexible pricing and quantity options that accommodate consumer financial realities.

According to Powell et al. (2021), micro-retail outlets fill supply gaps by providing daily necessities in quantities that align with household budgets. According to Mburu and Odhiambo (2019), research in East Africa shows that similar micro-retail systems adapt to local consumption practices by implementing flexible pricing, credit, and purchase cycles based on community cash flow patterns.

Sari-sari Stores in the Philippines

According to Villanueva (2025), sari-sari stores in the Philippines are small-scale retail enterprises that sell basic commodities in quantities that match variable household cash flows. These stores play a critical role in enabling daily consumption for low-income households who may lack access to formal retail.

According to Reyes (2025), Filipino consumers rely heavily on sari-sari stores for convenience and cost flexibility, making *tingi* buying a normative behavior rather than an exception. According to Santos (2025), transaction frequency in sari-sari stores has increased despite lower spending per visit, indicating consumer adaptation to constrained budgets.

According to Gamboa and Lapuz (2019), sari-sari stores serve as community anchors, facilitating social exchange, informal credit, and trust-based retail practices. According to Reyes, Cruz, and Delos Santos (2023), these stores tailor their product mix, price points, and volume offerings to local demand, reinforcing their role as adaptable retail institutions that support consumption stability in low-income neighborhoods.

In summary, the reviewed literature underscores that small-unit purchasing is shaped by a combination of financial constraints, socio-economic conditions, and retail accessibility. The synthesis identifies both global and Philippine trends while highlighting gaps in community-level research, particularly in areas like Saklangan, Verdant Homes Sabang Naic, Cavite. This establishes a strong rationale for the current study to investigate consumer behavior and preferences in local sari-sari stores.

Chapter 3: Research Methodology

This chapter presents the methodological procedures and tools employed by the researchers to conduct the study. It details the research design, subjects of the study, sampling method/technique, research instrument, statistical treatment of data, data gathering procedure, and ethical considerations. These components collectively guide the systematic collection, analysis, and interpretation of data to achieve the objectives of the research (Creswell, 2015).

A. Research Design

This study will employ a quantitative correlational research design to examine the relationships between income level, budget limitations, selected socio-economic factors, and consumer preference for small-unit purchasing (tingi buying) in sari-sari stores. The correlational design is appropriate because it allows the researchers to determine the strength and direction of associations among naturally occurring variables without manipulation (Creswell, 2015). While correlations reveal meaningful patterns, they do not establish causality, which is acknowledged as a limitation of this design (Field, 2018).

The study focuses on consumers residing in Saklangan and Verdant Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite, chosen for their high density of sari-sari stores and frequent small-unit purchasing behaviors. For sampling, the researchers will use cluster sampling, a probability sampling technique in which the population is divided into naturally occurring groups or clusters, and entire clusters are randomly selected for inclusion (Thomas, 2023). Cluster sampling is particularly useful when populations

are geographically dispersed, complete lists of individuals are unavailable, or resources for data collection are limited, while still maintaining representativeness and external validity (Salkind, 2026).

In this study, the clusters are the two geographic communities (Saklangan and Verdant Homes). Both clusters will be selected, and all consumers within the clusters who regularly engage in small-unit purchasing will be considered potential respondents. A total of 150 respondents is targeted, ensuring adequate representation of the larger population of small-unit buyers. Cluster sampling provides an efficient method for data collection and reduces logistical challenges, making it suitable for this field-based community research (Thomas, 2023).

This method also supports the quantitative correlational design by enabling systematic analysis of associations between income level, budget limitations, socio-economic factors, and consumer preferences, while minimizing selection bias in a community-based context (Salkind, 2026). This design allows the researchers to examine how demographic, economic, and socio-economic factors collectively influence consumer preference for small-unit purchasing in the selected communities.

B. Subject of the Study

The subjects of this study are 150 consumers who regularly purchase goods in small quantities (tingi buying) from sari-sari stores in Saklangan and Verdant Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite. The respondents were drawn using cluster sampling, where the population was divided into two geographic clusters corresponding to the two communities, and all consumers within these clusters who regularly engage in

small-unit purchasing were included (Thomas, 2023). This approach ensures that the sample represents the larger population of small-unit buyers while being practical and efficient for field-based data collection.

Participants were included based on the following criteria: residency within the selected communities and regular engagement in small-unit purchasing from sari-sari stores. These criteria ensure that respondents have direct experience with the phenomenon under investigation, enhancing the validity and reliability of the collected data (Kumar, 2019).

The selected respondents will complete a structured questionnaire designed to measure income level, budget limitations, socio-economic factors, and consumer preferences. Their participation will provide data directly relevant to the study's objectives. Ethical considerations, including voluntary participation, informed consent, and confidentiality, will be strictly observed throughout the data collection process to protect respondents' rights and ensure the integrity of the research (Winslow, 2025). This sampling ensures that the data collected accurately reflects consumer behavior regarding small-unit purchasing in the selected communities.

C. Sampling Method/Technique

The researchers will utilize cluster sampling, a type of probability sampling, to gather data from the respondents. In this method, the population is divided into naturally occurring groups or clusters, and entire clusters are selected to participate in the study (Taherdoost, 2016). For this research, the clusters are based on geographic location, specifically the two communities of Saklangan and Verdant

Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite. Cluster sampling is appropriate in this context because it allows the researchers to efficiently reach participants who share common characteristics while reducing time, effort, and logistical constraints associated with surveying a widely dispersed population (Kumar, 2019).

For the study, the researchers will select two clusters, representing the two communities. Within these clusters, all consumers who regularly engage in small-unit purchasing (tingi buying) at local sari-sari stores will be considered potential respondents. The total number of respondents expected from the selected clusters is approximately 150 consumers, ensuring a representative sample of the population. These respondents are drawn from an estimated total population of over 300 consumers across the two communities. This approach captures the collective behavior of consumers within these specific communities, providing accurate insights into purchasing patterns and preferences related to income level, budget limitations, and socio-economic factors.

Cluster sampling is particularly suitable for this quantitative correlational study because it enables the researchers to analyze patterns and relationships among variables efficiently and systematically (Taherdoost, 2016). Moreover, it reduces the potential for selection bias, as all individuals within selected clusters have the opportunity to participate, ensuring that the results are generalizable to the broader population of small-unit buyers in the targeted communities (Kumar, 2019).

D. Research Instrument

The primary instrument for this study will be a survey questionnaire, chosen for its reliability, efficiency, and suitability for quantitative research (Fowler, 2015). A survey allows researchers to collect standardized data from a large number of respondents in a structured manner, facilitating statistical analysis and comparison. This method is particularly appropriate for investigating behavioral variables such as income level, budget limitations, socio-economic factors, and consumer preference for small-unit purchasing (Bryman & Bell, 2015).

The questionnaire will consist of close-ended items and Likert-scale questions, designed to quantify respondents' purchasing behavior and perceptions related to small-unit purchasing. The structured format ensures consistency in responses and supports the use of correlational techniques such as Pearson's correlation and multiple regression analysis (Field, 2018).

Given the use of cluster sampling, the survey will be administered to all selected respondents within the chosen clusters (Saklangan and Verdant Homes), allowing the researchers to efficiently gather data from geographically grouped participants while maintaining representativeness (Salkind, 2026). This approach ensures that each cluster's population is adequately captured and reduces logistical challenges associated with individual random sampling across dispersed locations.

Due to the manageable sample size, responses will be analyzed both manually and with statistical software, ensuring accurate tabulation of frequencies, correlations, and predictor relationships among variables. This dual approach supports

a robust interpretation of results and aligns with the study's quantitative correlational design (Bryman & Bell, 2015).

E. Statistical Treatment of Data

To effectively interpret and analyze the collected data, the researchers will utilize correlational analysis, specifically the Pearson Product-Moment Correlation Coefficient Pearson's r , (Creswell, 2015). To determine the strength and direction of relationships between the study variables, including income level, budget limitations, selected socio-economic factors, and consumer preference for small-unit purchasing (Field, 2018).

Table 1: Interpretation of Pearson's r Correlation Coefficient

Size of Correlation	Interpretation
.90 to 1.00 (−.90 to −1.00)	Very high positive (negative) correlation
.70 to .90 (−.70 to −.90)	High positive (negative) correlation
.50 to .70 (−.50 to −.70)	Moderate positive (negative) correlation
.30 to .50 (−.30 to −.50)	Low positive (negative) correlation
.00 to .30 (.00 to −.30)	negligible correlation

By applying Pearson's r , the researchers aim to quantify the degree of association between the identified variables, providing a clear and objective understanding of how socio-economic factors influence consumer behavior in small-unit purchasing. This statistical approach ensures that the study's findings are data-driven and can support meaningful interpretations and conclusions regarding patterns and relationships within the target population.

The correlational analysis is the most often used in determining if there is a correlation between variables. The tabulated data will be treated with the use of Correlation Coefficient and Pearsons R. The following qualitative description was adapted to quantify the respondents'

Table 2: Pearson's r Correlation Coefficient Table

SCALE	EQUIVALENT DESCRIPTIVE RATIO
Never	1
Seldom	2
Often	3
Always	4

Likert Scale is a rating scale used to measure opinions, perceptions, and behaviors. This scale is used to understand respondent ratings to a series of statements about a topic to determine the cognitive and affective components of attitudes. This method allows researchers to quantify subjective attitudes, capturing both the direction and intensity of beliefs, and is commonly applied in fields such as psychology, education, marketing, and social sciences to assess the cognitive and affective components of attitudes (Bryman, 2016). Responses are numerically coded, enabling statistical analysis of patterns in perceptions and behaviors.

F. Data Gathering Procedure

The researchers will collect data using a structured survey questionnaire administered to 150 respondents who regularly engage in small-unit purchasing (tingi buying) from sari-sari stores in Saklangan and Verdant Homes, Sabang, Naic, Cavite.

Prior to data collection, informed consent will be obtained from each participant, explaining the purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of participation, and measures to ensure confidentiality (Palinkas, 2015). The questionnaire will be pre-tested on a small group of respondents outside the study sample to ensure clarity, reliability, and validity of the items (Bryman & Bell, 2015). After refinement, the survey will be distributed in person to the randomly selected respondents, with researchers providing clarification on key terms and guidance to ensure accurate understanding and responsible completion of the instrument (Bhardwaj, 2019). Respondents will be asked to answer honestly, and the researchers will collect all completed questionnaires for coding and analysis.

The data will be reviewed for completeness and consistency, then tabulated and analyzed using descriptive and inferential statistical methods, including Pearson's correlation coefficient, to determine relationships between income level, budget limitations, socio-economic factors, and consumer preference for small-unit purchasing (Field, 2018). Ethical standards, including confidentiality, voluntary participation, and accurate reporting of results, will be strictly observed throughout the process (Palinkas, 2015).

This procedure ensures that the collected data are accurate, reliable, and systematically organized. The results will provide insights into consumer behavior regarding small-unit purchasing and serve as a foundation for drawing conclusions and making practical recommendations for sari-sari store management and community consumption strategies. The researchers will ask a statistician to help in

determining the appropriate statistical tools in interpreting the data. Based on the data, the researchers will come up with the conclusions and recommendations for this study.

G. Ethical Consideration

The researchers will ensure that the study is conducted responsibly and that the rights and well-being of all participants are protected in accordance with established ethical standards for human research (Winslow, 2025). Prior to engaging in data collection, participants will be provided with sufficient information about the study's objectives, procedures, and expected use of data, and will be required to give informed consent voluntarily without coercion (Garcia-Iglesias, 2024). Participants will be assured that their identities will remain anonymous where possible and that all personal information will be treated with strict confidentiality, stored securely, and used only for the purposes of this research (Winslow, 2025). Respondents will be informed that they may refuse to participate or withdraw from the study at any time without penalty, and that their responses will be reported in aggregated form to protect privacy (BERA, 2024). These measures are designed to promote respect for persons, protect participant privacy, and uphold the integrity and trustworthiness of the research process.

The researchers also recognize that ethical responsibility extends beyond formal guidelines. Throughout the study, care will be taken to treat all participants with respect, ensuring their comfort and understanding at every stage. By maintaining transparency, protecting privacy, and honoring participants' rights, the study fosters a trustworthy environment where respondents can provide accurate and

honest information. Upholding these standards safeguards participants and strengthens the credibility and validity of the research findings.

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